

STATE-OF-THE-ART REVIEW

Congenital Long QT Syndrome



Andrew D. Krahn, MD,^a Zachary Laksman, MD, MSc,^a Raymond W. Sy, MBBS, PhD,^b Pieter G. Postema, MD, PhD,^c Michael J. Ackerman, MD, PhD,^{d,e,f} Arthur A.M. Wilde, MD, PhD,^{c,g} Hui-Chen Han, MBBS, PhD^{a,h}

ABSTRACT

Congenital long QT syndrome (LQTS) encompasses a group of heritable conditions that are associated with cardiac repolarization dysfunction. Since its initial description in 1957, our understanding of LQTS has increased dramatically. The prevalence of LQTS is estimated to be ~1:2,000, with a slight female predominance. The diagnosis of LQTS is based on clinical, electrocardiogram, and genetic factors. Risk stratification of patients with LQTS aims to identify those who are at increased risk of cardiac arrest or sudden cardiac death. Factors including age, sex, QTc interval, and genetic background all contribute to current risk stratification paradigms. The management of LQTS involves conservative measures such as the avoidance of QT-prolonging drugs, pharmacologic measures with nonselective β -blockers, and interventional approaches such as device therapy or left cardiac sympathetic denervation. In general, most forms of exercise are considered safe in adequately treated patients, and implantable cardioverter-defibrillator therapy is reserved for those at the highest risk. This review summarizes our current understanding of LQTS and provides clinicians with a practical approach to diagnosis and management. (J Am Coll Cardiol EP 2022;8:687-706) © 2022 by the American College of Cardiology Foundation.

Congenital long QT syndrome (LQTS) encompasses a group of heritable conditions that are associated with cardiac repolarization dysfunction.¹⁻⁴ The initial description of a hereditary syndrome causing QT interval prolongation, recurrent syncope, congenital deafness, and sudden cardiac death (SCD) was made by Jervell and Lange-Nielsen⁵ in 1957. Early work in LQTS sought to identify patients based on the clinical phenotype of prolonged QT on the surface electrocardiogram (ECG).^{6,7} With the advent of genetic testing, more patients are now identified on

the basis of a pathogenic variant with varying degrees of penetrance and phenotypic expression.^{8,9} Due to the potential risk for SCD and the availability of effective treatment options, it is vital for clinicians to be able to accurately identify and manage patients suspected of having LQTS. In this review, we summarize the current understanding of LQTS and provide a practical framework for its diagnosis, risk stratification, and treatment with a focus on the 3 major autosomal dominant LQTS genotypes: LQT1, LQT2, and LQT3 (Central Illustration, Table 1).

From the ^aCenter for Cardiovascular Innovation, Heart Rhythm Services, Division of Cardiology, University of British Columbia, Vancouver, BC, Canada; ^bFaculty of Medicine and Health, The University of Sydney, Sydney, New South Wales, Australia; ^cDepartment of Clinical and Experimental Cardiology, Heart Center, Amsterdam University Medical Centers, Amsterdam, the Netherlands; ^dDepartment of Cardiovascular Medicine, Division of Heart Rhythm Services, Windland Smith Rice Genetic Heart Rhythm Clinic, Mayo Clinic, Rochester, Minnesota, USA; ^eDepartment of Pediatric and Adolescent Medicine, Division of Pediatric Cardiology, Mayo Clinic, Rochester, Minnesota, USA; ^fDepartments of Molecular Pharmacology and Experimental Therapeutics, Windland Smith Rice Sudden Death Genomics Laboratory, Mayo Clinic, Rochester, Minnesota, USA; ^gEuropean Reference Network for Rare and Low Prevalence Complex Diseases of the Heart (ERN GUARD-Heart), Academic University Medical Center, Amsterdam, the Netherlands; and the ^hVictorian Heart Institute, Monash University, Clayton, VIC, Australia.

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ABBREVIATIONS AND ACRONYMS

APD = action potential duration
CE = cardiac events
ECG = electrocardiogram
ICD = implantable cardioverter-defibrillator
JLN = Jervell and Lange-Nielsen
LCSD = left cardiac sympathetic denervation
LQTS = long QT syndrome
SAE = serious arrhythmic events
SCD = sudden cardiac death
TdP = torsade de pointes

PATHOPHYSIOLOGY

POTASSIUM CHANNEL STRUCTURE AND FUNCTION. Voltage-gated potassium channels are transmembrane proteins that are essential for the regulation of cardiac repolarization, and are composed of an α -subunit and β -subunits.^{10,11} The α -subunit is composed of 4 homologous domains—each consisting of 6 segments—that coassemble into a pore-forming channel (Figure 1), allowing the movement of potassium ions across the plasma membrane along their electrochemical gradient.^{12,13} The auxiliary β -subunits are regulatory proteins (eg, cytoplasmic proteins, single transmembrane spanning domains, and transport related proteins), that modulate the function of the α -subunit through cell surface expression and gating.^{10,11}

Two subtypes of voltage-gated potassium channels—delayed rectifier channels $K_{V7.1}$ and $K_{V11.1}$, accounting for I_{Ks} (slow) and I_{Kr} (rapid), respectively—are primarily responsible for the outward potassium current during phase 3 of the ventricular action potential (Figure 2),¹⁴ which is critical for cardiac repolarization.¹² Under normal circumstances, the

HIGHLIGHTS

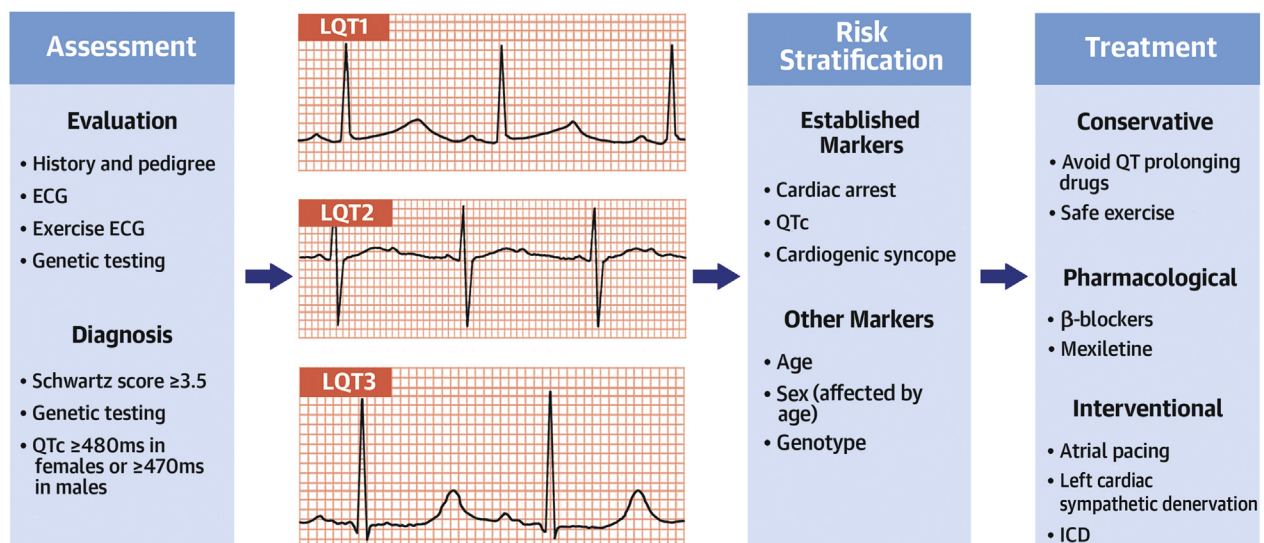
- Recently, there have been significant advances in our understanding of congenital LQTS.
- This review provides practical recommendations for the diagnosis and treatment of congenital LQTS.
- Further research is required regarding the pathophysiological understanding and risk stratification in congenital LQTS.

physiological function of both $K_{V7.1}$ and $K_{V11.1}$ are potentiated by adrenergic stimulation.^{15,16}

SODIUM CHANNEL STRUCTURE AND FUNCTION. Voltage-gated sodium channels are similar in structure to voltage-gated potassium channels, with the predominant isoform being $Na_v1.5$ in the human heart.¹⁷ Cardiac depolarization occurs as a result of sodium channel activation whereby a conformational change in the α -subunit leads to the rapid influx of sodium ions (I_{Na}).¹⁸

GENETICS OF LQTS. The majority of LQTS cases are caused by loss-of-function variants in voltage-gated potassium channels.³ Variants in genes encoding for

CENTRAL ILLUSTRATION Clinical Approach to Congenital Long QT Syndrome

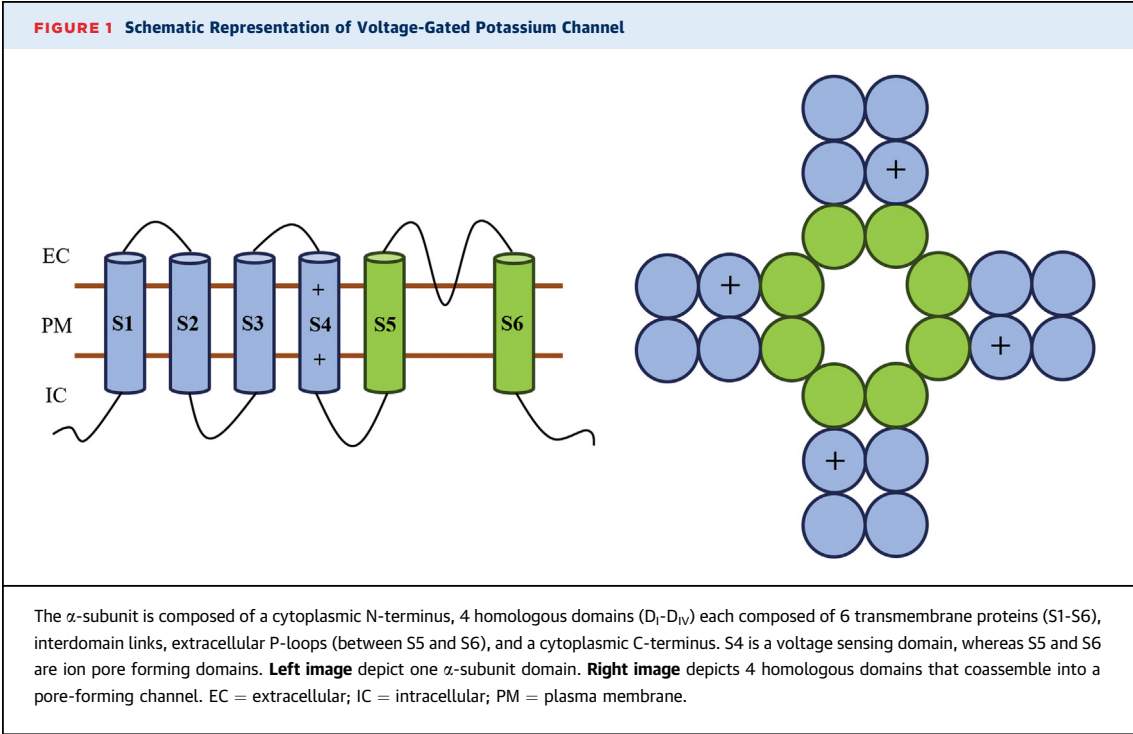


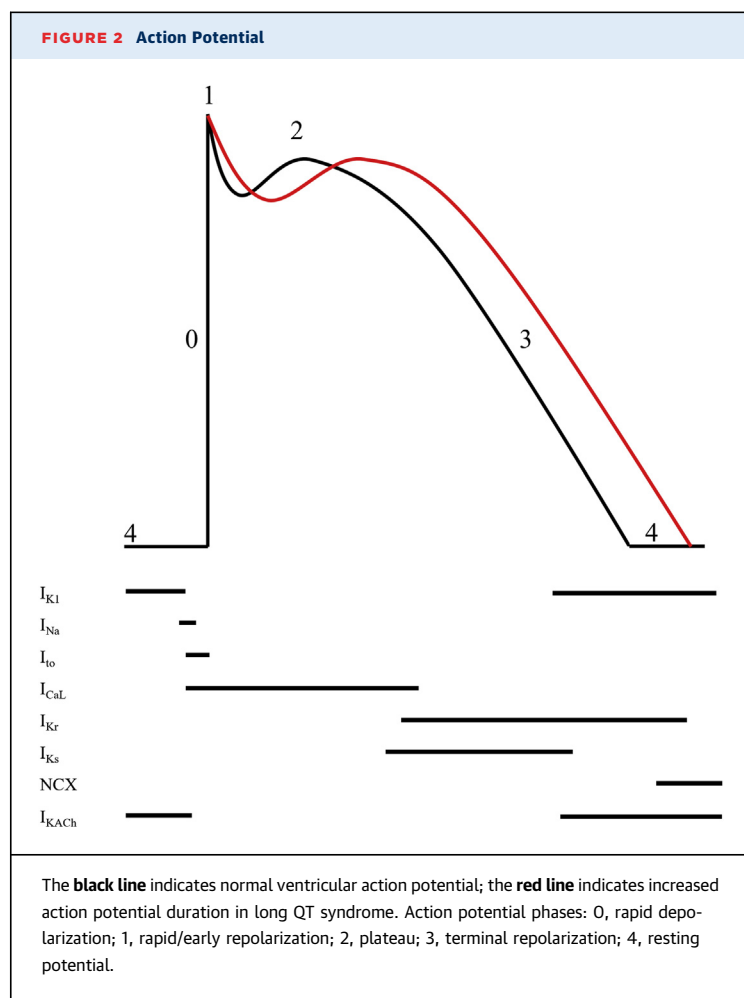
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ECG = electrocardiogram; ICD = implantable cardioverter-defibrillator; LCSD = left cardiac sympathetic denervation.

TABLE 1 Diagnosis and Management Summary for LQTS		
Diagnosis		
At Risk	Evaluation and Testing	Diagnostic Criteria
<i>Symptomatic</i> • Cardiogenic syncope • Ventricular arrhythmias • Resuscitated cardiac arrest <i>Asymptomatic</i> • Prolonged QTc interval • Abnormal T wave • Family screening	<i>Initial</i> • Clinical—syncope, family history, medical history, medications • ECG—QTc interval, T-wave morphology • Exercise test—QTc interval at 4-min recovery • Echocardiogram—exclude structural abnormalities <i>Discretionary</i> • Holter monitor • Further cardiac imaging as indicated • Genetic testing with involvement of genetics expert	<i>Definite</i> • Schwartz-score ≥ 3.5 • Pathogenic or likely pathogenic variant in LQTS gene • QTc interval ≥ 500 ms on repeated ECG^a <i>Probable</i> • QTc interval between 480 and 499 ms on repeated ECG^a <i>Possible</i> • LQTS risk score 2.0-3.5 in the presence of a family history of LQTS
Management		
Conservative	Pharmacologic	Interventional
<i>Avoid QT prolonging drugs and triggers</i> • For all patients with definite LQTS • Recommended for all patients with probable LQTS <i>Re-evaluation</i> • Consider re-evaluating patients with possible LQTS after 1-2 y	<i>β-blockers</i> • QTc interval ≥ 470 ms in patients with definite LQTS • Patients with cardiogenic syncope and definite LQTS • Patients with probable LQTS • Consider in patients with possible LQTS • Nonselective agents preferred <i>Mexiletine</i> • Consider as adjunctive therapy in LQT3 • Consider as adjunctive therapy in LQT2 with QTc interval ≥ 500 ms or syncope on β-blocker	<i>ICD</i> • Secondary prevention in resuscitated cardiac arrest • Consider for primary prevention in high-risk patients—breakthrough syncope or QTc interval ≥ 500 ms despite β-blocker ($\pm$ mexiletine and LCSD), JLN syndrome <i>Atrial overdrive pacing</i> • During acute ventricular arrhythmias <i>LCSD</i> • β-Blocker intolerance • Arrhythmic events despite β-blockers $\pm$ ICD
^a In the absence of medications or disorders known to affect these electrocardiographic findings. ECG = electrocardiogram; ICD = implantable cardioverter-defibrillator; JLN = Jervell and Lange-Nielsen; LCSD = left cardiac sympathetic denervation; LQTS = long QT syndrome.		

Kv7.1 and Kv11.1 account for ~80% of all genotype-positive LQTS cases.³ LQT1 is caused by pathogenic variation in *KCNQ1*, which encodes for the α -subunit of Kv7.1,^{3,10} whereas LQT2 is related to pathogenic variation in *KCNH2*, which encodes for the α -subunit of Kv11.1.^{3,10} These variants cause a reduction of outward potassium current during phase 3 of the ventricular action potential (Figure 2).¹⁴ Variants in





genes encoding for the β -subunits of $K_v7.1$ and $K_v11.1$ have also been reported in patients With LQTS (*KCNE1* causing LQT5 and *KCNE2* causing LQT6, respectively).¹⁹ Recent studies suggest a modulatory role that is associated with a weaker clinical phenotype,²⁰⁻²² although compound heterozygous variants in *KCNE1* result in the autosomal recessive Jervell and Lange-Nielsen (JLN) syndrome.²³

Additionally, variants affecting other cardiac ion channels are also described in LQTS. LQT3 is caused by a gain-of-function variant in the *SCN5A* gene, encoding for $Na_v1.5$,^{3,10} which causes persistent I_{Na} during the plateau phase of the action potential, with resultant prolongation of QT duration caused by delayed repolarization.²⁴

ACTION POTENTIAL DURATION AND ARRHYTHMOGENESIS. The net effect of the ion channel disturbances in LQTS is prolongation of the action potential duration (APD) through alterations in ion channel activation and inactivation, or ion channel

expression. Using induced pluripotent stem cells from 2 patients with LQT1 resulting from a missense variation in the *KCNQ1* gene, Moretti et al²⁵ showed that the ventricular myocyte APD at 90% repolarization was 554 ms in LQT1 compared with 373 ms in control subjects, which occurred as a result of a 70% to 80% reduction in I_{Ks} . Similar findings of APD prolongation have been demonstrated in other forms of LQTS.²⁶⁻²⁸

Under normal circumstances, sympathetic input with β -adrenergic stimulation of cardiomyocytes results in pleomorphic effects on various ion channels, including $K_v7.1$, $K_v11.1$, and $Na_v1.5$, resulting in the overall augmentation of depolarization and repolarization kinetics.²⁹ For example, I_{Ks} is enhanced by adrenergic stimulation, but this is diminished in the setting of defective $K_v7.1$ channels in patients with LQT1.²⁹ In patients with LQT2, β -adrenergic stimulation results in an increase of depolarizing currents but reduced repolarizing currents caused by defective $K_v11.1$ channels.²⁹ In patients with LQT3, there is an increase in late I_{Na} .²⁹ The resultant effect of these imbalances between depolarization and repolarization is lengthening of the APD,³⁰ with the occurrence of early after-depolarizations, which can then trigger torsade de pointes (TdP).^{25,26,31}

EPIDEMIOLOGY

The prevalence of LQTS is estimated to be ~1:2,000 based on a large newborn evaluation cohort, with a slight female predominance.^{9,32} However, there may be considerable overlap in the baseline QTc interval between those with genotype-positive LQTS compared with genotype-negative family members,^{9,33,34} whereas 1% to 10% of the general population may have a QTc interval ≥ 450 ms.^{34,35} Conversely, up to 40% of those with genotype-positive LQTS may have a baseline QTc interval that is within the normal range.^{8,9,36-38} LQTS accounts for 5% to 10% of young SCD cases referred for autopsy (diagnosed through molecular genetic testing and/or phenotype testing of family members),³⁹ and ~15% of cases with “unexplained” resuscitated cardiac arrest (after exclusion of coronary artery disease and structural heart disease).^{40,41}

DIAGNOSIS

GUIDELINE RECOMMENDATIONS. The diagnosis of LQTS remains anchored to the LQTS diagnostic criteria score (also known as the ‘Schwartz-score’), which is an important tool for the initial clinical

TABLE 2 Schwartz Score

	Points
ECG findings^a	
A QTc interval ^b , ms	
≥480	3
460-479	2
450-459 (males)	1
B QTc interval ^b ≥480 ms at 4-min recovery from exercise stress test	1
C Torsade de pointes ^c	2
D T-wave alternans	1
E Notched T wave in 3 leads	1
F Low heart rate for age ^d	0.5
Clinical history	
A Syncope ^e	
With stress	2
Without stress	1
B Congenital deafness	0.5
Family history^f	
A Family member with definite LQTS	1
B Unexplained sudden cardiac death age <30 y among immediate family members	0.5

Score ≤1, low probability; 1.5 to 3, intermediate probability; ≥3.5, high probability. Reproduced with permission from Schwartz et al.³ ^aIn the absence of medications or disorders known to affect these electrocardiographic findings. ^bQTc interval calculated by Bazett formula $QTc = QT/\sqrt{RR}$. ^cMutually exclusive. ^dResting HR <2nd percentile for age. ^eSame family member cannot be used for both A and B. Abbreviations as in Table 1.

assessment of patients suspected of having LQTS (Table 2).³ It is composed of ECG findings, clinical history, and family history. Importantly, ECG findings should be interpreted in the absence of QT-prolonging agents or other reversible causes. A Schwartz-score of ≥3.5 carries a specificity of 99% (with sensitivity between 19% and 36%) for the diagnosis of LQTS.^{37,42}

Expert consensus guidelines from the Heart Rhythm Society, European Heart Rhythm Association, and Asia Pacific Heart Rhythm Society indicates that LQTS is definitely diagnosed in the setting of a Schwartz-score ≥3.5, the presence of a pathogenic variant or repeated measures of QTc interval ≥500 ms in the absence of QT-prolonging drugs,⁴² although we would recommend involvement of a genetics expert if diagnosing LQTS primarily based on genetic results.

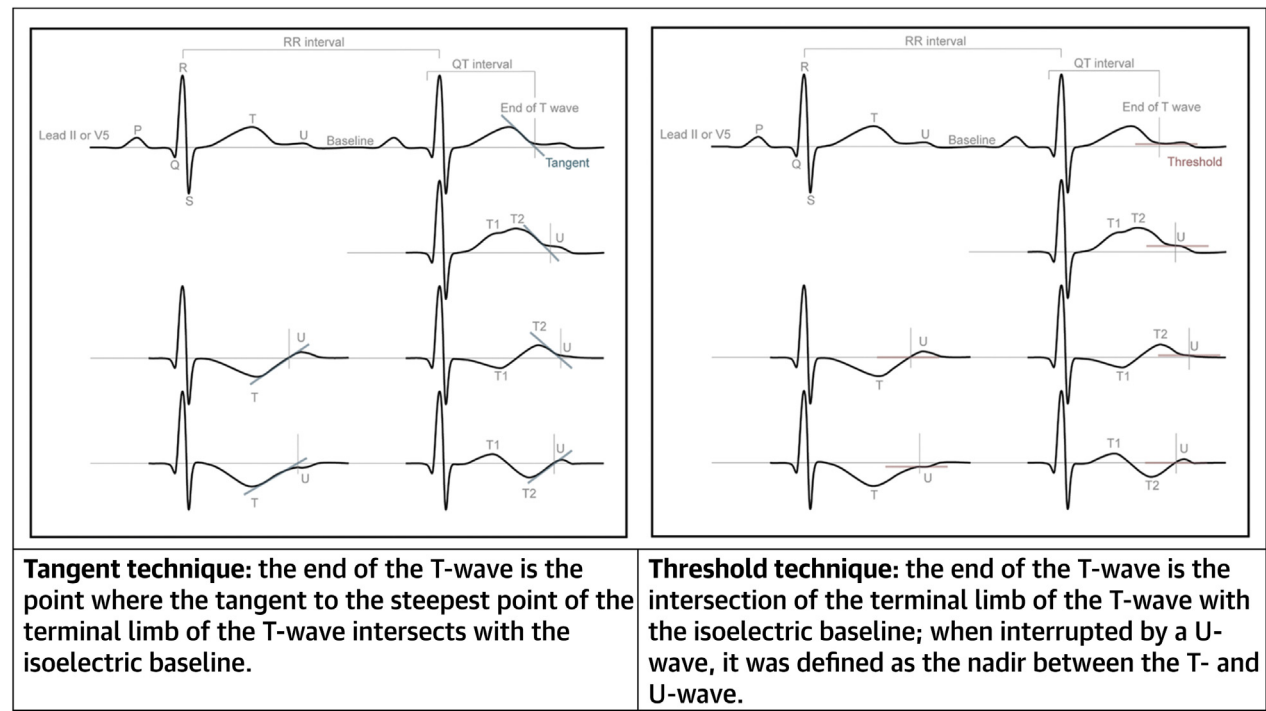
An important consideration is that patients who are diagnosed with “acquired” LQTS may in fact have underlying congenital LQTS that is unmasked with QT-prolonging drugs.⁴³ In an international cohort of patients with apparent acquired LQTS, about one-fourth of patients harbored a pathogenic LQTS gene variant.⁴⁴ Hence, patients with apparent acquired LQTS should be evaluated after drug cessation.

CLINICAL MANIFESTATIONS. Recurrent syncope, caused by TdP,⁴⁵ is frequently described in patients with LQTS. Classically, these episodes are triggered by exercise (particularly swimming) in patients with LQT1, and by sudden auditory stimuli (such as alarm clocks) in LQT2.⁴⁶⁻⁴⁸ Additionally, episodes may also occur in the setting of emotional stress (for LQT1, LQT2, and LQT3),⁴⁸ during sleep or rest, but without arousal (particularly for LQT3),⁴⁸ or in the postpartum period for female patients with LQT2.⁴⁹ In patients who present with syncope, a detailed clinical assessment is required to differentiate likely cardiogenic syncope from other potential causes such as vasovagal syncope.⁵⁰

Other clinical manifestations in patients with LQTS include seizures, atrial arrhythmias, and SCD or resuscitated cardiac arrest. There is also appreciable overlap between LQTS and epilepsy.⁵¹ This is especially true in patients with LQT2 who harbor specific *KCNH2* variants,⁵¹⁻⁵³ and it is recognized that disturbance of potassium homeostasis in the hippocampus may result in epileptic activity.⁵¹ Perturbations of cardiac repolarization seen in LQTS may also affect the atria.⁵⁴ Consequently, there is an increased risk of atrial arrhythmias, although this appears most evident for patients under the age of 60 with LQT3.⁵⁵ As noted, LQTS may also be identified after an episode of resuscitated cardiac arrest or at postmortem after SCD, supporting the development of population screening programs.^{48,56} Finally, with the advent of genetic testing, a significant proportion of patients are now asymptomatic at the time of clinical diagnosis.^{42,57} This shift in diagnostic paradigm is in contrast to the original seminal research from the International Long QT Registry that enrolled a cohort of patients and family members with a relatively severe disease phenotype.⁵⁸

BASELINE ECG. The surface ECG remains fundamental in the initial assessment for LQTS. In general, calculation of the QT interval in lead II or V₅ offers the best combination of measurability, identification of gene variant carriers, and identification of high-risk individuals.⁵⁹ Suitable alternative leads include V₂ or V₃, which may provide a longer measured QT interval,⁶⁰ but is associated with lower predictive power in the identification of gene variant carriers compared with control subjects.⁵⁹ The QT interval is measured from the beginning of the QRS complex to the end of the T wave. Standardized assessment using either a tangent or threshold technique (Figure 3) enables high interobserver and intraobserver reproducibility and diagnostic accuracy.^{9,61} Although both techniques are valid and accurate, associated cutoff

FIGURE 3 Tangent and Threshold Methods for QT Measurement



Reproduced with permission from Vink et al.⁹

values for distinguishing LQTS patients from control subjects vary, whereby the tangent method results in QT measurements that are ~10 ms shorter.⁹ Clinicians should be careful in distinguishing the second component of a biphasic T-wave from a U-wave, and exclude any present U-waves in the measurement of the QT interval.⁹ An online tool that provides an estimate about the likelihood of a patient having LQTS is available at the University of Amsterdam Medical Center's QT calculator.

Given the heart rate dependence of the QT interval,⁶² the rate-corrected QTc interval is used for the diagnosis of LQTS. Various formulas exist for QT correction,⁶³ with subsequent effects for the diagnostic cutoffs for LQTS⁹; readers are directed to work from Vandenberk et al⁶³ and Vink et al⁹ for a detailed comparison of these techniques. However, the formula that is most commonly implemented in clinical practice was developed by Bazett in 1920,⁶² defined as: $QTc = QT/\sqrt{RR}$. Although it overestimates the QTc interval compared with other methods,^{63,64} the Bazett formula is applied in the current diagnostic criteria for LQTS.³ The ECG is a contextual test, and thus pretest probability based on clinical

circumstances is crucial. In a healthy population, most slightly prolonged QTc intervals represent the healthy upper limit of normal findings, and not genetically mediated LQTS. A resting QTc interval ≥ 450 ms in men or ≥ 460 ms in women—in the absence of medications or other conditions affecting the QTc interval—increases the pretest possibility for LQTS.³ As noted however, these cutoff values may be exceeded in 1% to 10% of the general population,³⁴ whereas the QTc interval may be within the normal range in up to 40% of genotype-positive patients.^{9,37} Furthermore, an additional 30% may have a borderline QTc interval (up to 470 ms in males and up to 480 ms in females).⁸ Hence, additional clinical evaluation is critical before assigning a diagnosis of LQTS.

In addition to prolongation of the QTc interval, patients with LQTS may exhibit morphological T-wave changes. The initial descriptions for T-wave changes in LQTS included broad, biphasic, notched, and the presence of beat-to-beat T-wave alternans.^{65,66} Subsequent genotype studies identified typical T-wave patterns for the 3 most common forms of LQTS (Figure 4): LQT1 patients frequently have a



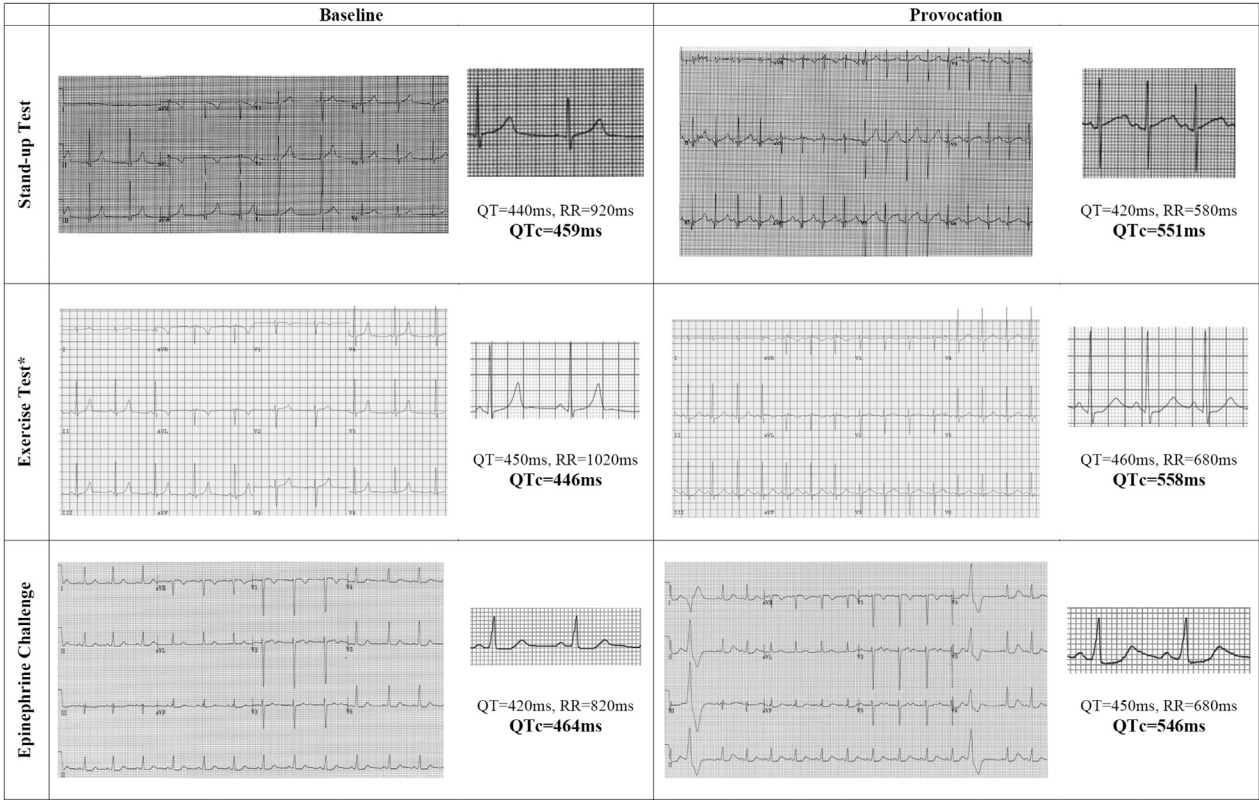
broad-based T-wave pattern; LQT2 patients frequently have a low-amplitude bifid T-wave pattern; and LQT3 patients frequently have a peaked or biphasic T-wave pattern that can be late onset or asymmetrical.^{2,67,68} Interestingly, the presence of giant T waves (sometimes termed T-U waves due to their size) are reported to herald episodes of TdP.⁶⁹

PROVOCATION TESTING. In cases of diagnostic uncertainty, provocation testing is often helpful for the identification of gene variant carriers.⁷⁰ Provocation testing for LQTS involves assessment of

repolarization in response to autonomic changes,⁷¹ particularly during the acceleration and deceleration of heart rate. Although the QT and QTc interval are known to be influenced by heart rate alterations in normal individuals,⁶² a maladaptive repolarization response is frequently seen in patients with LQTS.

Exercise testing in LQTS allows for an extended assessment of QT and T-wave changes during both acceleration and deceleration phases.^{8,72,73} Outcomes have been described for various forms of exercise testing, including the standard or modified Bruce protocol treadmill test and bicycle ergometry.

FIGURE 5 Changes in QTc Interval With Provocation Testing



*Provocation electrocardiogram performed at 4-minute recovery.

A protocol is described for QT measurements irrespective of the mode of exercise (Supplemental Table 1).⁸ Although various measures of repolarization have been investigated, the measure with the highest diagnostic value during exercise testing is the QTc interval at 4-minute recovery (Figure 5, Supplemental Table 2),^{8,70} with a QTc interval ≥ 445 ms offering 90% sensitivity and 90% specificity for diagnosing LQTS or a QTc interval ≥ 480 ms offering 36% sensitivity and 100% specificity for diagnosing LQTS.⁸ The latter cutoff has been incorporated into the updated Schwartz-score for the diagnosis of LQTS,⁷⁰ although it should be noted that this measure is only validated for patients with LQT1 and LQT2. Importantly, a prolonged QTc interval during exercise recovery is validated in children with LQTS, although the recommended duration of recovery monitoring is longer (optimal QTc interval measurement >460 ms at 7-minute recovery).⁷² Changes in QTc interval during exercise and recovery may also be useful for distinguishing

between LQTS genotypes, whereby patients with LQT1 have the greatest increase in QTc interval during exercise with gradual shortening during recovery, whereas patients with LQT2 have QTc interval shortening during exercise with gradual lengthening during recovery.^{8,72,73} Consequently, differences in QTc interval during peak exercise or at 1-minute recovery could help differentiate between LQT1 and LQT2.

Abrupt standing from a supine position may also result in changes to the QTc interval, which can be performed in a clinic or incorporated into a standard exercise test (Supplemental Table 1).⁷⁴⁻⁷⁸ Patients with LQTS exhibit both immediate and extended increases to their QTc interval when compared with control subjects (Figure 5, Supplemental Table 2). Overall, the measure with the highest diagnostic value during the stand-up test is the QTc interval during maximal QT stretch (defined as the time when the end of the T wave gets nearest to the next P-wave caused by R-R interval shortening without sufficient QT interval shortening),⁷⁶⁻⁷⁸ with a

$QT_{\text{stretch}} \geq 490$ ms offering 92% sensitivity and 79% specificity for diagnosing LQTS.⁷⁸ However, this measure is not validated in pediatric patients,^{72,79} whereby abrupt standing can result in a QT_c interval increase of up to 80 ms, even in healthy children.^{80,81}

Changes in heart rate and repolarization are also described using pharmacologic provocation with epinephrine (Figure 5, Supplemental Table 1).^{82–89} However, the heart rate response to epinephrine may be variable,⁸⁴ and induction of ventricular bigeminy or marked changes to T-wave morphology can adversely affect the test interpretation.^{90,91} Therefore, the utility of the epinephrine challenge test as a stand-alone diagnostic tool for LQTS is limited, although it may be considered in patients who are unable to perform exercise.⁹²

Active mental stress, such as mental arithmetic, may also provoke repolarization changes in patients with LQTS.^{93,94} However, there is currently no universal agreement regarding the timing of QT measurements,^{93–95} while the effects of baseline education and language proficiency may further confound results.⁹⁶ The active mental stress test requires standardization and clinical validation.

GENETIC TESTING. Genetic testing is recommended in those with a Schwartz-score ≥ 3 ,^{3,37,97} although the identification of a culprit genetic variant ranges between 50% and 80% of cases depending on the pre-test probability.^{61,98,99} Additionally, differences in the global availability and cost of genetic testing also present as potential implementation barriers.¹⁰⁰ The 3 major genotypes—*KCNQ1* (~40%–45%), *KCNH2* (~40%) and *SCN5A* (~5%–10%) genes causing LQT1, LQT2, and LQT3, respectively^{19,101}—account for the vast majority of genotype-positive LQTS cases and have the strongest level of evidence for causal pathogenicity.^{3,22} Several “minor” LQTS genes (such as *CAV3*, *KCNE1*, *KCNE2*, *KCNJ2*, *KCNJ5*, and *SCN4B*) are now considered as “limited evidence” LQTS-susceptibility genes^{3,22} resulting from the recent update of sequence variant interpretation as recommended by the American College of Medical Genetics.¹⁰² The careful curation of identified gene variant(s) is critical before ascribing pathogenicity, and a practical approach would be to involve a genetic expert in this process. Interpretation should account for the frequency of the variant in population databases, its anticipated effect on protein function (based on in vitro and in vivo studies), and linkage studies. With the recent identification of possible polygenic influences in LQTS patients¹⁰³ and recognition regarding the need for periodic variant

reinterpretation,¹⁰⁴ it is evident that our understanding of the genetics in LQTS is ever-evolving and therefore may be subject to further reclassification.¹⁰⁵

FAMILY SCREENING. Cascade screening should be performed on all first-degree relatives of patients with LQTS. If a proband has an identified gene variant, targeted genetic testing should be performed in their first-degree relatives—family members who carry the gene variant should undergo clinical assessment. If a proband is gene elusive, all first-degree relatives should undergo clinical assessment. Screening for additional relatives (eg, second degree relatives) should be considered if an intervening relative cannot be tested, or in the presence of a clinical phenotype.

We would recommend that clinical assessment include baseline testing with ECG and exercise testing. Results from the initial evaluation would guide any additional testing and the frequency of follow-up testing.

OTHER TESTS. Although not necessary for the diagnosis, a baseline echocardiogram should be performed in all patients being assessed for LQTS for the exclusion of structural heart disease.

RISK STRATIFICATION

Patients with LQTS are at risk of developing serious arrhythmic events (SAE), encompassing SCD and resuscitated cardiac arrest. Thus, risk stratification in LQTS patients aims to identify those with a greater likelihood of SAE (Table 3). These are influenced by various clinical, ECG, and genetic factors, and an understanding of these factors can allow for shared decision-making regarding therapies.

CLINICAL. The risk of cardiac events (CE, which includes SAE and syncope) and SAE in LQTS appears greatest in childhood and gradually diminishes with time.^{106–108} Older patients with LQTS—especially those aged >60 years—have an attenuated risk of SAE from LQTS compared with younger patients, and a higher competing risk of mortality from other conditions.¹⁰⁹

The additional influence of patient sex results in an apparent age-sex interaction. In a cohort of 2,272 adolescent LQTS patients, Hobbs et al¹¹⁰ found that male sex conferred a 4.0× relative risk of SAE between the ages of 10 and 12 years. This was reinforced by Costa et al¹¹¹ in a cohort of 1,051 LQT1 patients, where they found male sex was associated with a 2.3× relative risk of SAE up until age 13 years. During mid to late adolescence, there appears to be relatively

TABLE 3 Summary of Select Risk Stratification Markers

Category First Author	Study Population	N	Outcome	Risk Marker	Comparator	Odds Ratio
Clinical						
Rashba ¹²¹	LQT pregnancy	111	SAE	Postpartum	Pre-pregnancy	40.8
Hobbs ¹¹⁰	LQT age 10-20 y	2,772	SAE	Male (10-12 y)	Female (10-12 y)	4.0
				Syncope	No syncope	2.7-18.1
Sauer ¹¹²	LQT ≥18 y	812	SAE	β-Blocker	No β-blocker	0.36
				Female	Male	2.68
				Syncope	No syncope	5.10
Moss ¹⁴⁰	LQT1	600	CE <40 y	β-Blocker	No β-blocker	0.40
				Male (<13 y)	Female (<13 y)	1.72-1.94
Seth ⁴⁹	LQT pregnancy	391	SAE	Postpartum	Pre-pregnancy	4.1
Goldenberg ¹⁰⁹	LQT, age 41-60 y	924	SAE	Recent syncope	No recent syncope	9.92
Jons ¹¹³	LQT, QTc interval ≥450	1,059	SAE	Female (14-40 y)	Male (14-40 y)	1.86
				β-Blockers	No β-blocker	0.46
				Syncope on β-blocker	No syncope	3.59
Liu ¹²²	LQT, age <20 y	1,648	SAE	Syncope	No syncope	6.54-14.65
				β-Blocker	No β-blocker	0.20-0.28
Migdalovich ¹²³	LQT2	1,166	SAE <40 y	Female (14-40 y)	Male (14-40 y)	2.23
				Syncope	No syncope	3.15
Goldenberg ³⁸	LQT, QTc interval >440	1,392	SAE <40 y	Female (>13y)	Male (>13 y)	1.90
Costa ¹¹¹	LQT1	1,051	SAE <40 y	Male (0-13 y)	Female (0-13 y)	2.31
				Syncope	No syncope	3.40
Mullally ¹¹⁴	LQT	403	SAE <40 y	Female	Male	2.25
Laksman ¹¹⁵	LQT	113	CE	Female	Male	5.21
Wilde ¹²⁴	LQT3	391	SAE <40 y	Syncope	No syncope	2.03
Koponen ¹³⁰	LQT1/2 age 18-40 y	867	CE	Female	Male	3.18
				β-Blocker	No β-blocker	0.19-0.40
Sugrue ¹¹⁶	LQT	651	CE	Female	Male	2.39
QTc interval						
Zareba ¹²⁷	LQT	246	CE <40 y	10-ms increment QTc interval		1.06
Priori ¹²⁹	LQT on β-blocker	335	CE	QTc interval >500	QTc interval ≤500	2.01
Goldenberg ¹²⁵	LQT age 10-20 y	375	CE	QTc interval ≥500	QTc interval <500	2.74
Sauer ¹¹²	LQT ≥18 y	812	SAE	QTc interval ≥500	QTc interval <500	3.34-6.35
Moss ¹⁴⁰	LQT1	600	CE <40y	QTc interval ≥500	QTc interval <500	1.88-3.25
Jons ¹¹³	LQT, QTc interval ≥450	1,059	SAE	QTc interval >500	QTc interval ≤500	1.76
Migdalovich ¹²³	LQT2	1,166	SAE <40 y	QTc interval ≥500	QTc interval <500	3.24
Goldenberg ³⁸	LQT, QTc interval >440	1,392	SAE <40 y	10-ms increment QTc interval		1.08
Costa ¹¹¹	LQT1	1,051	SAE <40 y	QTc interval ≥500	QTc interval <500	3.35-4.18
				QTc interval >500	QTc interval <500	2.22
Mullally ¹¹⁴	LQT	403	SAE <40 y	QTc interval ≥500	QTc interval <500	2.22
Laksman ¹¹⁵	LQT	113	CE	QTc interval >500	QTc interval ≤500	4.50
Wilde ¹²⁴	LQT3	391	SAE <40 y	10-ms increment QTc interval		1.33
Koponen ¹³⁰	LQT1/2 age 18-40 y	867	CE	QTc interval ≥500	QTc interval <500	2.22-2.66
Shimizu ¹²⁸	LQT1/2	1,008	CE	10-ms increment QTc interval		1.06-1.09
Sugrue ¹¹⁶	LQT	651	CE	10-ms increment QTc interval		1.07

Continued on the next page

similar risk between both sexes,^{110,111} at least in those with LQT1.¹¹⁰ Transitioning into adulthood, female sex results in an increased relative risk of both CE and SAE.¹¹²⁻¹¹⁶ Sauer et al¹¹² showed that between ages 18 and 40 years, the rate of CE was 40% in females, compared with 14% in males, whereas the rate of SAE was 11% in females compared with 2% in males.

The reasons for these observations likely stem from the effects of sex hormones on potassium channels,¹¹⁷ whereby testosterone and progesterone potentiate I_{Ks} , whereas estrogen inhibits I_{Kr} .¹¹⁸ In postpubertal males, increased levels of testosterone

result in a reduced QT interval.^{119,120} In females, there appears to be competing effects of estrogen (which causes an increase in QT) and progesterone (which causes a decrease in QT),¹¹⁹ although this requires further elucidation. For example, although both estrogen and progesterone increase during pregnancy and decrease during the postpartum period, relative differences in the hormones may explain why women experience more events during the postpartum phase with nonsignificant differences during pregnancy.^{49,121} This effect is particularly evident in women with LQT2.⁴⁹

TABLE 3 Continued

Category	First Author	Study Population	N	Outcome	Risk Marker	Comparator	Odds Ratio
Genetic							
Zareba ¹²⁷		LQT	246	CE <40y	LQT1/2	LQT3	3.43-5.49
					LQT1	LQT2	1.58
Moss ¹³⁸		LQT2	168	CE <40 y	Pore	Non-pore	10.7-11.7
Priori ³⁶		LQT	647	CE <40 y	LQT2/3	LQT1	1.61-1.80
Priori ¹²⁹		LQT on β -blocker	335	CE	LQT2/3	LQT1	2.81-4.00
Shimizu ¹³⁹		LQT1	66	CE	Transmembrane	C-terminus	3.4
Goldenberg ¹³²		LQT	2,218	CE	JLN syndrome	RW syndrome	5.51
Crotti ¹³⁵		LQT1	449	CE <40 y	A341V	Non-A341V	4.0
Moss ¹⁴⁰		LQT1	600	CE <40 y	Transmembrane	C-terminus	2.06
					Dominant negative	Haploinsufficiency	2.26
Goldenberg ¹⁰⁹		LQT, age 41-60 y	539	SAE	LQT3	LQT1	4.53
Liu ¹³⁶		LQT3	85	CE <40 y	Δ KPQ	D1790G	2.42
Migdalovich ¹²³		LQT2 males	490	SAE <40 y	Pore-loop	Loop or C/N term	2.04-2.18
Goldenberg ³⁸		LQT, QTc interval $\leq$ 440	469	SAE <40 y	LQT1	LQT2	9.88
					Transmembrane	Nontransmembrane	6.32
		LQT, QTc interval >440	1,392		LQT1	LQT2	0.53
Wilde ¹²⁴		LQT3	391	SAE <40 y	E1784K/D1790 mutation		0.09-0.30
Koponen ¹³⁰		LQT1/2 age 18-40 y	867	CE	LQT2	LQT1	2.11
Mazzanti ¹³¹		LQT	1,710	SAE	LQT2/3	LQT1	2.23-4.00
Shimizu ¹²⁸		LQT1/2	1,008	CE	S5-pore-S6	N/C terminus	1.64-1.99
Sugrue ¹¹⁶		LQT	651	CE	LQT3	LQT1	0.28

QTc values are in milliseconds.

CE = cardiac events; JLN = Jervell and Lange-Nielsen; LQT = long QT; LQTS = long QT syndrome; RW = Romano-Ward; SAE = serious arrhythmic events.

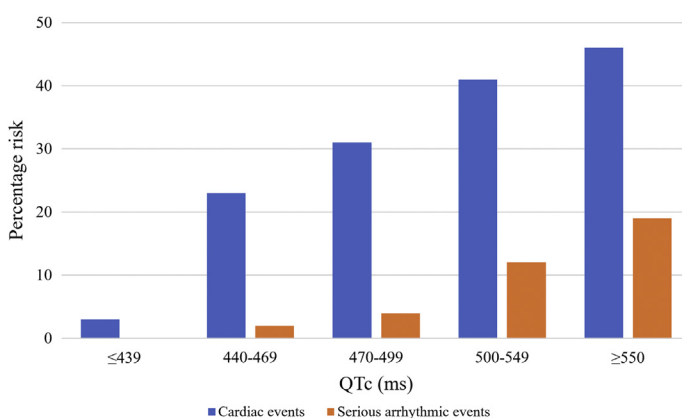
Finally, the occurrence of syncope is independently associated with the SAE with a relative risk of at least 2.0,^{109-113,122-124} which is greater in those with recent (within 2 years) and/or recurrent syncope.^{109,110,112,122}

QTc INTERVAL. QTc prolongation, which is the phenotypic manifestation of LQTS, imparts significant influence on the risk stratification of these patients. It should be noted that many of the risk-stratification studies are from the International LQTS Registry, which used the threshold method for QT measurement and included a cohort of patients with a more severe phenotype. Furthermore, it is important to consider the clinical utility of repeated measures of QTc interval, because studies have shown that the maximum measured QTc interval on serial ECG provides greater prediction of CE.^{113,125,126}

Consistent evidence has shown that higher QTc values correlate with an increased incidence of CE (Figure 6).^{36,38,112} Studies are typically retrospective cohorts with varying degrees of treatment (including many untreated subjects), so the cited risks combine natural history with on-treatment risk. In a study of 812 patients with genotype-positive LQTS (18% of cohort prescribed β -blockers), Sauer et al¹¹² showed a step-wise gradient of events. For patient groups with QTc interval $\leq$ 439 ms, 440 to 469 ms, 470 to

499 ms, 500 to 549 ms, and $\geq$ 550 ms, the corresponding risk of CE over 22 years (between ages 18 and 40 years) was 3%, 23%, 31%, 41%, and 46%, respectively, whereas the risk of SAE between ages 18 and 40 years was 0%, 2%, 4%, 12%, and 19%, respectively.¹¹²

FIGURE 6 Risk of Cardiac Events and Serious Arrhythmic Events Stratified by QTc Interval



Cardiac events = syncope + serious arrhythmic events. Serious arrhythmic events = resuscitated cardiac arrest + sudden cardiac death. Developed using original data reported by Sauer et al.¹¹² CE = cardiac events; SAE = serious arrhythmic events.

This step-wise gradient is supported by findings of an increased HR for CE or SAE of ~ 1.1 for every 10-ms increment in QTc interval.^{38,116,124,127,128} When dichotomized based on QTc interval, patients with a QTc interval ≥ 500 ms are ~ 2 to 3 times more likely to experience CE or SAE compared with LQTS patients with a QTc interval < 500 ms,^{110,111,114,123,125,129,130} including those who are medically managed with β -blockers.¹²⁹ Pragmatically, the application of a QTc ≥ 500 ms is a reasonable approach for the identification of high-risk patients with LQTS, because this corresponds with a 1.9% to 2.1%/year incidence of CE and 0.5% to 1.3%/year incidence of SAE.^{112,131} By contrast, gene carriers with a QTc interval < 500 ms have a low incidence of SAE at 0.2% to 0.4%/year,^{112,131} whereas those with a QTc interval < 460 ms are at very low risk for SAE at $< 0.1\%$ /year.^{38,112,131}

GENETIC. Although the autosomal recessive JLN form of LQTS and other compound heterozygote patients are associated with the most severe clinical outcomes,^{107,132,133} additional genetic factors influence risk of both CE and SAE in LQTS.

With regard to genotype, initial work by Priori et al³⁶ found an annual incidence of SAE for LQT1 at 0.3%, LQT2 at 0.6%, and LQT3 at 0.6%. Our current understanding would estimate that the annual rate of SAE up to the age of 40 in LQT1 is 0.2% to 0.5%, LQT2 is 0.3% to 0.7%, and LQT3 is 0.3% to 1.1%.^{111,112,123,124,131,134} Corresponding estimates for the annual rate of CE up to the age of 40 in LQT1 is 0.8% to 1.1%, LQT2 is 0.8% to 1.8%, and LQT3 is 0.5% to 1.5%.^{36,55,112,124,135,136} Stratified further, Nannenberg et al¹⁰⁸ found that the specific period of increased mortality for LQT1 was between 1 and 19 years, for LQT2 was between 30 and 39 years, and for LQT3 was between 15 and 19 years.

With the advancement in the genetic understanding of LQTS, we now appreciate that there appears to be significant variation in the overall risk within long QT genotypes. In comparing a cohort of 438 genotype LQT1 patients ($\sim 50\%$ prescribed β -blockers), Crotti et al¹³⁵ showed that presence of the A341V variant was associated with an 80% risk of experiencing a CE by age 40 years, compared with only 30% in those with LQT1 based on different causal variants. By contrast, Winbo et al¹³⁷ found a very low incidence (0.05% per year) of SAE in 80 Swedish patients (62.5% prescribed β -blockers) with the founder Y111C variant of LQT1 during 25 years of follow-up. Similarly, for cohorts of genotype-positive LQT3 patients, the presence of an E1784K or D1790G variant is associated with significantly less CE,^{124,136} whereas those with Δ KPQ are at higher risk.¹³⁶

Additional genetic markers have characterized variants depending on their location within the potassium channel. Consistent evidence indicates that variants affecting the transmembrane pore carry the highest relative risk of events, followed by variants affecting other transmembrane domains (but not specifically the pore region), with N or C terminus domains being associated with the lowest risk of events.^{38,123,128,138-140} Furthermore, variants that result in a dominant negative effect convey greater risk than those resulting in haploinsufficiency.¹⁴⁰ Finally, various single nucleotide variation (formerly single nucleotide polymorphism) have been shown to influence the risk of both CE and SAE in LQTS.^{126,141} These findings provide a plausible—at least partial—explanation for the variation in relative risk estimates when comparing subtypes of LQTS based on initial genetic studies.^{36,127} Overall, the genetic risk stratification in LQTS is inherently complex and extends beyond the isolated identification of LQT subtype, requiring a multidisciplinary approach to variant interpretation and therapeutic recommendations.

OTHER FACTORS. Although LQTS is traditionally associated with normal left ventricular structure and function, cardiac imaging parameters may provide additional risk stratification.^{116,142} In a cohort of 651 patients with LQTS, Sugrue et al¹¹⁶ found that a more negative electromechanical window (defined as electromechanical window = time from QRS onset to aortic valve closure – QT interval for the same beat) was independently associated with the presence of symptoms. This interesting finding requires prospective evaluation and external validation.

MANAGEMENT

CONSERVATIVE. Nonpharmacologic management of LQTS involves the avoidance of QT-prolonging drugs and trigger avoidance. In those with asymptomatic LQTS and normal QTc interval (genotype positive, with little or no phenotype), conservative measures may be all that is required.¹⁴³

An up-to-date list of drugs that can cause QT prolongation can be found at the CredibleMeds website or the related smartphone app,¹⁴⁴ including both prescription and nonprescription medications. Although this is an undoubtedly invaluable resource, it should be noted that the inclusion of most drugs is based on case report evidence with little systematic data regarding the degree of QT prolongation.¹⁴⁵ Nevertheless, it is crucial for patients to be educated about medications that are contraindicated in LQTS, especially given that there is suboptimal awareness

TABLE 4 Approach to Initiation of Possible QT-Prolonging Medication in LQTS Patient

1. Assessment of baseline risk (eg, age, sex, QTc interval) and protective factors (eg, ICD)
2. Consider inpatient admission in high-risk cases
3. If possible, select medication with least QT-prolonging effects from the appropriate class
4. Have an LQTS specialist available to interpret ECG if there is concern
5. Perform resting ECG before initiation
6. Use lowest possible dose for desired efficacy
7. Perform repeat ECG after reaching steady-state (typically 3-7 days) from medication initiation or dose increase
8. Contact LQTS specialist if QTc interval ≥ 500 ms or if there is a 30-ms increase in the QTc interval (would require additional surveillance with consideration of medication cessation)

Abbreviations as in Table 1.

among prescribers.¹⁴⁶ Patients should be cognizant that this also includes certain drugs commonly obtained as illicit substances such as amphetamine/methamphetamine, cocaine, oxycodone, and quetiapine. In cases where concomitant QT-prolonging medications are clearly indicated, consultation with a LQTS expert for shared decision-making and enhanced monitoring is advised (Table 4).

Our understanding regarding recreational and competitive sports in patients with LQTS is evolving. Based on cohort studies of predominantly pediatric and adolescent patients undertaking both recreational and competitive sports, the overall sport-related event rates in treated LQTS appears low.¹⁴⁷⁻¹⁵⁰ Thus, in patients who are adequately assessed, treated and educated, sports participation can be considered appropriate.^{151,152} The authors encourage recreational physical activity in medically treated, stable patients with its many health benefits. A shared decision-making process involving patients, families, and potentially sports team representatives to create a participation plan is strongly advised. One specific contraindication is swimming alone for LQT1 patients,¹⁵¹ where the potential consequences of exertional syncope (which in itself may not be fatal) is compounded by the additional drowning risk.

PHARMACOLOGICAL. Pharmacological therapy with β -blockers is fundamental in the management of LQTS patients who are symptomatic for CE and/or have QTc prolongation. Treatment with β -blockers results in a minor reduction of resting QTc interval^{153,154} and may ameliorate exercise-induced changes in QTc interval.^{155,156} Pathophysiologically, β -blockers are thought to counteract the sympathetically induced heterogeneity in regional electrophysiology and reduces early after-depolarization triggers.^{29,31} Large cohort studies consistently show

that treatment with β -blockers results in a significant reduction of both CE and SAE (relative risk: 0.4-0.5 compared with those not treated with β -blockers).^{110,112,113}

The treatment response is not universal across the β -blocker agents, and varies by genotype. The literature supporting β -blocker therapy pertains to its use in LQT1 and LQT2, with more data required with regard to LQT3.¹⁵⁷ Evidence suggests that treatment with nadolol results in the greatest risk reduction in the overall LQTS population,^{131,158} being effective for both LQT1 and LQT2 patients.¹⁵⁸ Interestingly, propranolol may offer greater reductions in QTc interval,¹⁵³ although it is proposed that its efficacy is predominantly in patients with LQT1.¹⁵⁸ If nonselective agents cannot be tolerated, use of metoprolol, atenolol, or bisoprolol may be considered.^{154,158}

Other important considerations in β -blocker therapy include adequate dosing, patient adherence, and its continued use during pregnancy. For nadolol, a target dose of 1 mg/kg/day is recommended,¹⁵⁹ with evening dosing or divided doses to minimize potential side effects. The occurrence of breakthrough CE and SAE are often described for patients who are nonadherent to β -blocker therapy.^{148,160,161} In a study investigating pharmacy dispensing data in patients with LQTS, Waddell-Smith et al¹⁶² found that over one-half of patients who are prescribed β -blockers had suboptimal adherence. This suggests that the relative risk reduction associated with optimal β -blocker therapy may be significantly greater than what is reported. In addition, continuation of β -blockers is considered safe during pregnancy^{163,164} and reduces maternal risk especially in the postpartum period^{49,121,165}; additional discussions about β -blocker use in LQTS and pregnancy is provided by Roston et al.¹⁶⁵ Thus, it is critical for clinicians to provide adequate education regarding the importance of β -blocker therapy for patients with LQTS.

A practical approach for assessing sufficient β -blocker effect is the demonstration of blunting of heart rate response with exercise testing. Rather than aiming for QTc shortening, the authors aim for heart rate blunting of 15% to 20% during maximum exercise to demonstrate adequate effect and adherence. Of note, certain patients may not require lifelong β -blocker therapy, such as those with shorter resting QTc intervals or older patients.¹⁴³

Recently, the Class IB sodium channel-blocker mexiletine has demonstrated good efficacy as an adjunctive pharmacologic agent in the treatment of LQTS. In patients with LQT3, who have a gain-of-function variant in their Na_v1.5 sodium channel,

mexiletine therapy at a dose of 8 mg/kg per day resulted in a significant (60 ms) reduction in QTc interval while reducing CE.¹⁶⁶ Interestingly, significant reductions in QTc interval have also been reported in patients with LQT2 receiving mexiletine.¹⁶⁷ The potential role for mexiletine in the treatment of LQTS warrants further investigation.

From small cohort studies, additional medical therapies that may shorten QTc interval include nicorandil (through its potentiation of potassium channels),¹⁶⁸ long-term potassium replacement therapy,¹⁶⁹ ranolazine (though sodium channel blockade) for LQT3,¹⁷⁰ and lumacaftor-ivacaftor (through potentiation of $K_{V11.1}$ channel trafficking).¹⁷¹⁻¹⁷³ These therapeutic options require validation in larger cohorts.

DEVICE THERAPY. In patients with LQTS and a history of resuscitated cardiac arrest, a secondary prevention implantable cardioverter-defibrillator (ICD) is indicated.⁴² The decision regarding insertion of a primary prevention ICD is more challenging, requiring consideration of the absolute risk of SCD balanced against the absolute risk of device-related complications.^{174,175} Two large retrospective cohort studies of patients with LQTS and ICD both found that a significantly prolonged QTc interval (≥ 500 ms) or cardiogenic syncope despite β -blocker therapy were independent predictors of appropriate ICD shocks,^{176,177} whereas the presence of JLN syndrome is also known to portend to a significant SCD risk (35% by age 40 years despite β -blocker therapy).¹³² By contrast, a meta-analysis of 462 LQTS patients with ICD found a 2.8% annual rate of inappropriate shocks, and a 7.0% annual rate of other complications such as lead malfunction, device infection, and psychological consequences.¹⁷⁸ Nevertheless, the authors would consider a shared decision-making discussion regarding primary prevention ICD (or left cardiac sympathetic denervation—see later in the text) for patients <40 years of age with JLN syndrome or compound heterozygotes (2 or more culprit variants), or patients who are adequately treated with β -blocker ($\pm$ mexiletine) but still have a QTc interval ≥ 500 ms or recurrent cardiogenic syncope.

For patients undergoing ICD insertion, a dual-chamber transvenous device offers the potential benefit of atrial overdrive pacing during episodes of acute ventricular arrhythmias¹⁷⁹ or for the prevention of pause dependent QT prolongation. For this reason, there is currently minimal experience using subcutaneous ICD in patients with LQTS. From the limited available evidence in the EFFORTLESS S-ICD (Evaluation of Factors Impacting Clinical Outcome and

Cost Effectiveness of the S-ICD) registry, patients with LQTS do not appear to be at increased risk of inappropriate shocks when compared with other patients.¹⁸⁰

Pacemaker therapy (without ICD) may be considered in certain circumstances. In addition to preventing pause-dependent or bradycardia-related TdP,¹⁸¹ pacing may ameliorate dynamic QT changes associated with heart rate variability. Long-term cardiac pacing may also result in a small reduction in overall QTc interval^{182,183} and enable adequate titration of β -blocker therapy. In a small cohort of high-risk pediatric patients with JLN syndrome, the combination of atrial pacing and β -blockers was reported to be effective for the prevention of SAE.¹⁸⁴

Finally, counselling for acquiring an automated external defibrillator may be considered in individuals with LQTS who do not undergo ICD insertion,¹⁸⁵ although the evidence for this course of action is limited.

LEFT CARDIAC SYMPATHETIC DENERVATION. Left cardiac sympathetic denervation (LCSD) can reduce the number of CE in patients who are already treated with β -blockers, or as potential monotherapy in those who are intolerant of β -blockers.¹⁸⁶⁻¹⁸⁹ Despite the invasive nature and risk of complications, high-risk patients undergoing LCSD generally express satisfaction with the result.^{190,191} LCSD is usually reserved for those who are intolerant of pharmacologic therapy or those with breakthrough CE after being treated with pharmacologic therapy. In certain high-risk patients (particularly LQT1), LCSD may be considered an appropriate or even preferred alternative intervention to the implantation of a primary prevention ICD.

FUTURE DIRECTIONS

Although patients with LQTS display a maladaptive repolarization response to changes in heart rate, there is still much to learn about the underlying pathophysiology. Recent studies have suggested that autonomic instability may contribute to symptoms and ventricular arrhythmias in patients with LQTS.^{192,193} Furthermore, studies involving QT/QTc hysteresis in patients with LQTS indicate that their QT intervals are different during exercise when compared with recovery for a given heart rate,^{57,75,77,194} suggesting repolarization variability depending on the level of sympathetic and parasympathetic input. Further work is required to delineate the role of the autonomic nervous system in relation to repolarization changes in patients with LQTS.

The diagnosis of LQTS is also evolving. For example, the foundations for the Schwartz-score was developed almost 30 years ago, before the identification of LQTS disease causing genes.¹⁹⁵ Although this is utilized by clinicians as a diagnostic tool, it is also a screening tool to determine which patients may be referred for genetic testing,⁶¹ which in itself may lead to a diagnosis of LQTS. Additionally, phenotypic LQTS involves more than just the QT (and QTc) interval—as Peter Schwartz has reiterated on numerous occasions, “I don’t measure the QT interval, I look at it.”⁴ Thus, the development of machine learning algorithms for the assessment of T-wave morphology,¹⁹⁶⁻¹⁹⁸ and also genetic prediction,¹⁹⁹ may result in the improved detection of LQTS patients.²⁰⁰

Related to this is the potential for an algorithm-based risk stratification model. In addition to identifying T-wave morphology for diagnosis, the quantitative assessment of T-wave abnormalities may improve risk stratification.²⁰¹⁻²⁰³ Furthermore, there is currently an abundance of risk stratification markers that are independent predictors of CE and SAE when accounting for age, sex, QTc interval, and genotype. However, the interplay between these markers is largely unknown, whereas decisions based on risk stratification would benefit from establishing the annual SAE rate in addition to the relative risk.

The contemporary management of LQTS is evolving as clinicians become more exposed to those who have a genetic diagnosis with a more benign clinical phenotype.²⁰⁴ Consequently, it would be important to identify patients in whom therapies are not necessarily required.¹⁴³ Finally, the refinement of medical therapies for LQTS is ongoing. For example, mexiletine significantly reduces the QTc interval in cohorts of LQT3 and LQT2 patients.^{166,167} Whether this reduction in QTc interval leads to a reduction in CE and SAE in larger cohorts would be of interest. Of concern, mexiletine’s recent designation as a neuromuscular “orphan drug” threatens the accessibility for patients with LQTS.²⁰⁵ Other emerging therapies also show promise by providing a cellular ability to “correct” LQTS. Lumacaftor-ivacaftor aims to restore ion channel function,¹⁷¹ and is currently used in patient with cystic fibrosis.²⁰⁶ An in vivo study in 2 LQT2 patients, showed that lumacaftor-ivacaftor can result in significant QTc shortening, presumably by restoring potassium channel function.¹⁷² Finally, in vitro studies using induced pluripotent stem

cell-derived cardiomyocytes has indicated promise for *KCNQ1* ion channel antibodies for the restoration of I_{Ks} function,²⁰⁷ *KCNQ1*-suppression-and-replacement gene therapy for the shortening of APD,²⁰⁸ and serum and glucocorticoid kinase-1 inhibition that can ameliorate the gain-of-function of $Na_v1.5$ seen in LQT3.²⁰⁹

CONCLUSIONS

Congenital LQTS is a heterogeneous group of conditions occurring caused by maladaptive cardiac repolarization. The assessment of clinical, ECG, and genetic factors are important for both the diagnostic evaluation and risk stratification of patients with LQTS. Management of patients with 1 of the 3 major LQTS genotypes requires an understanding of the various conservative, pharmacologic, and interventional treatment modalities, which are collectively very effective in mitigating risk.

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ADDRESS FOR CORRESPONDENCE: Dr Andrew D. Krahn, Center for Cardiovascular Innovation, Heart Rhythm Services, Division of Cardiology, University of British Columbia, 211-1033 Davie Street, Vancouver, BC V6E 1M7, Canada. E-mail: akrahn@mail.ubc.ca. Twitter: [@HeartsInRhythm](https://twitter.com/HeartsInRhythm).

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APPENDIX For supplemental tables, and references, please see the online version of this paper.